

My big worry was that the government may direct the LIC and maybe even some of the state-owned banks to support the market by making purchases. Something like that would help stabilize the market and prompt bears like me to start covering my positions. By now, many players were short on the market, and if all of them rushed to cover at the same time, the market might just take off.

There was no public statement by the finance minister or any other senior ministry official. But if the market fell any further, there would surely be some soothing words from the government to assuage the rattled investors. Or maybe SEBI would declare a ban on further short sales just before the market opened, setting off a stampede among bears to cover up their positions. Still, my trader's instinct told me there was one more round of sell-off coming, as many brokers and traders were still struggling to pony up cash to pay margins on their outstanding positions.

I slept fitfully that night. Despite all the money that was waiting to pour into my bank account, I still had this nagging worry that the market could once again change course abruptly and dent my profits. After all, I still had outstanding positions. Perhaps my sleeplessness reflected my guilt complex, as I had been making money while many of my friends were in dire straits.

I had strange dreams that night. In one of them, I was arguing with my friends who had accused me of being selfish and not helping them out even though I had the resources to. In another, a cop turned up at my doorstep with an arrest warrant, saying SEBI had identified a set of people who were spreading terror in the market through short-selling. Ignoring my pleas, he walked me through the streets with handcuffs on, much to the delight of the onlookers who were clapping in glee.

When I protested, the cop told me he had orders to make an example out of me so that people would stop short-selling. Perhaps this particular segment of my dream had to do with an inflated sense of self-worth that I was behind the market crash.

As I headed to work next day, the nightmare of my arrest and parade through the streets was playing on my mind. But my run of luck continued that morning, with the indices crashing 10 per cent within minutes of the start of trading, leading to market-wide circuit filters being triggered. Trading was suspended for an hour, according to rule.